

“WAR IS ONE OF THE SCOURGES WITH WHICH IT HAS PLEASED GOD TO AFFLICT MEN.”

Cardinal Richelieu, chief minister of France, 1620s

IN AUGUST 1624, CARDINAL RICHELIEU (1585–1642) became chief minister to the king of France, 23-year-old Louis XIII (1601–43). Richelieu claimed that his goals were “to destroy the military power of the Habsburgs, to humble the great nobles [of France], and to raise the prestige of the **House of Bourbon** in Europe.” It was ambitious, and involved alliances with groups that had little commitment to his program. Eventually, the price of confronting enemies abroad and Protestants at home would be popular revolt in France against the financial and military burdens imposed by him. It would also lead to rebellion by the elites that culminated in the civil war of the

Fronde (see 1648–49). His political **astuteness and manipulation of factions**, however, prevented political breakdown, and by his death, France was making progress against its Habsburg enemies. Richelieu also knew that Huguenot military power at home (see 1597–98) was a permanent threat to France’s stability, but that the persecution of Protestant worship would lead to last-ditch resistance at home and imperil France’s alliances with foreign Protestant powers, on which its **anti-Habsburg strategy** rested.

In 1625, the already tangled conflicts of the unfolding **Thirty Years’ War** became even more complex. With the Twelve-Year Truce over, Spain squeezed the

Dutch, **taking Breda after an 11-month siege**, while France, whose policy was now being directed by the hawkish Richelieu, became covertly involved in supporting an **anti-Habsburg struggle in northern Italy**.

This was an attempt by Richelieu to sever the Spanish Road, the tenuous but vital link between Habsburg Italy and the Netherlands. At almost precisely the same moment, Christian IV of Denmark (1577–1648) entered the war, in part seeking to **bolster the Protestant cause**, but more particularly to forestall Swedish ambitions to control northern Germany and the Baltic. In August 1626, his army was **defeated at the Battle of Lutter** (see right) by

a Bavarian Catholic army led by Count Tilly and in alliance with the Habsburg emperor. It seemed for the moment that French scheming and Dutch fighting could not prevent a comprehensive victory for the Habsburgs.

The Surrender of Breda

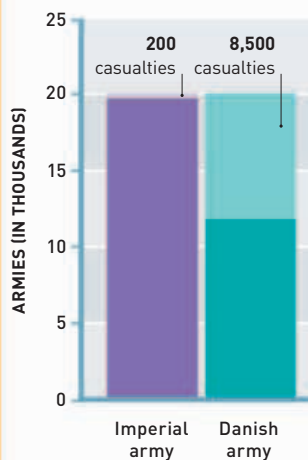
Justin von Nassau is shown surrendering Breda in 1625 to Ambrosio Spinola, the Spanish commander, after an 11-month-long siege. Breda was retaken in 1637.



This illustration shows Peter Minuit purchasing the island of Manhattan from the local American Indians, most likely the Lenape people, in 1626.

ONE OF THE MOST FAMOUS EVER TRANSACTIONS occurred on May 26, 1626 when **Peter Minuit**, director-general of the Dutch West India Company’s New Netherlands settlement, **bought Manhattan island**—site of Fort Amsterdam since 1625—from its American Indian inhabitants. The fee was 60 Dutch guilders, estimated since to be around \$24. Neither side felt the deal to be overly unreasonable.

The **Thirty Years’ War** was a **brutal watershed** in 17th-century Europe, but its cruelty was not merely a grim consequence of battle. Always strapped for money, armies took funding into their own hands and **imposed taxes directly** on the peasants and the towns. Faced by the collection of



Battle of Lutter

In 1626, a Danish army, with a huge loss of about 8,500 men, failed to hold ground against a similar-sized Holy Roman Empire force.



BAROQUE ARCHITECTURE

Gathering pace in the early 17th century, the Roman High Baroque was a strong Catholic response to the Protestant Reformation, and reasserted classical Renaissance architecture. Its church building, in particular St. Peter’s Basilica in Rome (pictured), sought to advertise and glorify the Catholic Church, and produced numerous new and grandiose buildings.

overly heavy taxes by soldiers, peasants and poor townspeople became even more **vulnerable to fluctuations in food supply** through bad harvests, military activity, and looting. Across much of Europe, but notably in France, the Austrian Habsburg lands, and Spanish southern Italy, **peasant revolts and urban riots** threatened to take whole areas out of the control of government. With the onset of the Little Ice Age in the mid-17th century (see 1645), the problem intensified.

